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Leslie Kern

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RESHAPING THE BOUNDARIES OF PUBLIC AND PRIVATE LIFE: GENDER, CONDOMINIUM DEVELOPMENT, AND THE NEOLIBERALIZATION OF URBAN LIVING¹

*Leslie Kern*²

**School of Women's Studies
York University
Toronto, Ontario, Canada**

Abstract: Taking feminist research as a starting point into the ways in which gentrification shapes gender relations in the city, this article addresses the phenomenon of new-build gentrification in terms of the re-contouring of gendered boundaries of public and private urban life. I examine how a widespread process of condominium development in Toronto is informed by neoliberal policy imperatives such as growth and competition. I also explore the ways in which the neoliberal, political-economic rationality underlying condominium development translates into changes in the ways that a particular group of city dwellers, women condominium owners, conceptualize their relationships to their homes, neighborhoods, and the city at large. This study suggests that condominium living produces a shift in the way that public and private spaces are understood and experienced, and that this shift has contradictory implications for the reshaping of urban gender relations. [Key words: New-build gentrification, gender, condominiums, Toronto, neoliberal urbanism.]

INTRODUCTION

A decade ago, Liz Bondi (1998) argued in this journal that contemporary urban landscapes, specifically landscapes of gentrification, might redefine the traditional boundaries between public and private space, potentially producing certain class-specific changes in the gendering of cities. This important article invited further research on the ways in which processes of urban change in postindustrial cities are connected to gendered ideologies about city living, and how such processes may produce changes in women's everyday urban lives. Unfortunately, there has been little further empirical research on the links between growth-oriented urban revitalization processes such as new-build gentrification, changing notions of public and private space, and gendered experiences of gentrification (Karsten, 2003; Billig, 2005; Vaiou and Lykogianni, 2006). In this study, I examine how widespread condominium development in Toronto is shaped by neoliberal policy imperatives such as growth and competition; however, I also explore the ways in which the neoliberal political-economic rationality underlying condominium development

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²Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Leslie Kern, School of Women's Studies, York University, Toronto, ON, M3J 1P3, Canada; e-mail: lkern@yorku.ca

translates into changes in the ways that a particular group of city dwellers—women condominium owners—conceptualize their relationships to their homes, neighborhoods, and the city at large. I suggest that condominium living does in fact produce a shift in the way that public and private spaces are understood and experienced, and that this shift has contradictory outcomes for women in terms of the “emancipatory potential of urban living” (Bondi, 1998, p. 180).

In a wider sense, this study grapples with the ways in which urban citizenship, as a process of claiming social, political, and economic rights in the city (Isin, 1999; Fenster, 2005), is being imagined and experienced in the context of neoliberal urban agendas. Property redevelopment is a key component of a package of “neoliberal policy experiments” (Brenner and Theodore, 2002, p. 368) aimed at producing a competitive, deregulated, and privatized city—a leaner, meaner growth machine described by Neil Smith (1996) as the revanchist city. Despite the centrality of property relations to the politics of the revanchist city, there have been few studies aimed at conceptualizing the links between property development and everyday practices of urban citizenship or attachment to place, particularly from a feminist perspective (Billig, 2005). The pervasive and long-term consequences of a massive wave of condominium development on social, political, and economic relations in a major city have not been explored in detail within the critical gentrification literature, despite the recognition that new-build gentrification is a significant force shaping the neoliberal city (Smith, 2002; Davidson and Lees, 2005). Even though a decade-long process of condominium construction may lack the drama of the expulsion of the homeless from New York’s Tompkins Square Park (Smith, 1996), the privatization of Berkeley’s People’s Park (Mitchell, 1995), or the demolition of Toronto’s “Tent City” (Welsh and Shephard, 2002), I argue that it is extremely important to pay attention to this phenomenon as a potentially more insidious and far-reaching form of revanchist urbanism. This article therefore aims to contribute a theoretically informed empirical analysis of the ways in which a particular form of property development, the condominium, shapes city lives in ways that resonate with (and/or challenge) neoliberal attempts to produce self-governing, consumption-oriented, autonomous urban citizens (Isin, 1999; Osborne and Rose, 1999).

However, while condominium development can certainly be conceptualized and problematized as an expression of neoliberal urbanism or revanchist practices, these frameworks leave little space to explore the impacts of residential intensification and the expansion of homeownership in the central city as crucial moments in the redefinition of urban community and urban citizenship. In other words, the impacts of these transformations on everyday life, for particular groups across the city, are not necessarily captured by the notion that such new-build gentrification is a straightforward, revanchist process of privatization. We must still ask, how does this process of neoliberal privatization translate into changes in everyday life? What are the consequences for democratic citizenship, or social justice for marginalized groups, in the neoliberal city? Following Wendy Larnier’s (2003) assertion that neoliberalism cannot be analyzed as a monolithic regime with predictable outcomes (see also Peck, 2004; Leitner et al., 2007), I suggest that it is helpful to examine neoliberal urbanism not as a pure process of privatization, but as a process wherein the meanings of public and private are shifted in ways that are quite context-specific, and at times uneven or contradictory. Feminist scholars have long argued that the concepts of public and private space are relational and mutually

constitutive, and that it is their construction, not their ontological reality, that must be problematized in order to challenge the oppressive ideologies and practices that arise from the notion of separate spheres (Pateman, 1989; Duncan, 1996; Stacheli and Mitchell, 2004). Feminist theory thus provides a theoretical basis (as well as a methodological approach) from which to explore the changing contours of women's relationship to the city through the notion that condominium living alters the boundaries of public and private space in ways that change the basic "architecture of citizenship" (Bickford, 2000) in contemporary cities. This approach allows me to explore Bondi's (1998) hypothesis that landscapes of gentrification offer, at best, unclear results in terms of women's emancipation in urban space.

In the first part of this article, I present a case study of North America's largest condominium market (Toronto), examining the political-economic logic behind the "roll-out" (Peck and Tickell, 2002) of condominiums in the context of Toronto's imperatives for growth and competition. The second part of the article offers an analysis of interviews conducted with women condominium owners in Toronto, investigating the ways in which condominium living shapes their engagements with, and attachments to, their communities and their city.

THE CONDOMINIUM AGENDA

We have become a nation living in concrete boxes, thrust into the sky. More than 17,000 new condos sold in Greater Toronto last year—the most ever in the history of the area. And we don't take a back seat to any place else on the continent. (Wong, 2006, p. A1)

These rather poetic comments made by *Toronto Star* real estate reporter Tony Wong in the spring of 2006 suggest that the scale and intensity of condominium development in Toronto is remarkable and unique. These features surely qualify Toronto as a site of inquiry; however, it is the rise of condominiums at a particular political-economic moment that makes Toronto an important case study. In the context of Toronto's global city aspirations (Kipfer and Keil, 2002), condominiums are expected to fulfill expanding housing needs, curb suburban sprawl, lift the spaces of deindustrialization to their highest and best use, respond to a cultural shift in favor of urban living, and stimulate the economy by providing sites for capital investment. Here I trace the ways in which intensification, redevelopment, and increased urban homeownership have been positioned as natural, inevitable, and even desirable choices within the context of neoliberal rationality. But this story also illustrates aspects of the mutability and instability of neoliberalism, in that it is unclear whether condominium development will indeed produce the kind of economic and social outcomes that are seemingly desired by the competitive city.

Troubling Tenure: Homeownership and the Reproduction of Neoliberal Urbanism

Condominium living in Toronto is not a new phenomenon. Since apartment ownership was made possible through the Ontario Condominium Act in 1967, condominiums have formed part of Toronto's highly diversified housing stock, serving as both owner-occupied and rental dwellings across the city. A condominium boom in the early 1980s

was brought to an abrupt halt when the high proportion of speculator-driven sales caused a crash in the market. Through the late 1980s and early 1990s, there was very little condominium construction, as most new housing came in the form of low-rise, single-family homes located in the steadily sprawling suburbs. Since the late 1990s, however, new condominium construction and sales have climbed to record-breaking figures almost every year. At the end of 2006, nearly ten years into this boom, the Greater Toronto Home Builders' Association (GTHBA) reported that new high-rise condominium sales in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA) comprised 44% of the market over the course of the year (Greater Toronto Home Builders' Association, 2007). Unlike the highly speculative 1980s boom, the majority of condominium units are owner-occupied, and many are rented out as long-term investments.

This is a phenomenal transformation in residential morphology for a city that had experienced major sprawl since the postwar period (Harris, 2004). But the more significant story, I argue, is the shift in the tenure structure of the city. Due in large part to the condominium boom, in 2001 the percentage of owner-occupied dwellings in Toronto surpassed that of rented dwellings—51% owner-occupied vs. 49% rented (City of Toronto, 2003)—for the first time since the major postwar housing boom of the 1950s and 60s (Choko and Harris, 1990).³ More than 75% of condominiums are owner occupied (City of Toronto, 2003). Despite a large supply of condominiums on the market, demand has not abated, with hundreds of projects under way across the city. Although high-rise, high-density living is not new in Toronto (it was certainly heavily promoted and enjoyed a certain degree of popularity in the 1960s and 70s; Darby, 1969), this demand was met by rental apartment buildings, the construction of which was subsidized by various levels of government. Moreover, nonprofit cooperative housing was subsidized for many decades (Wekerle, 1988, 1993, 2005). Now, however, homeownership is a key dimension of the current shift in residential tenure.

In order to understand why the private ownership dimension of condominium development is significant, it is necessary to note the national and local culture of property that shapes both the macro-level economic and political policies that favor homeownership, and the ideals and expectations of housing consumers. Canadian housing policy has always favored private homeownership, supporting citizens' attempts to attain this tenure through a variety of financial incentives and entitlements (Wekerle, 1997; Hulchanski and Shapcott, 2004). More importantly, though, owner-occupancy has been positioned as a social norm to the extent that "the culture of homeownership is integral to the North American way of life" (Choko and Harris, 1990). Recent popular discourse reproduces this culture, particularly through the message that renting is an inferior and undesirable form of tenure (Prashad, 2004). As Nicholas Blomley argues, gentrification proceeds in part because of "'common-sense' assumptions about property, such as the 'naturalness' of displacement, or the beneficial effects of middle-class ownership in poor neighbourhoods" (2004, p. xviii). This culture of property presumes that private ownership constitutes the highest and best use of urban space. In the context of entrepreneurial governance strategies, this culture of property shapes housing options in the city through the widespread

³These data are drawn from the 2001 Canadian Census.

assumption that the middle class will be drawn anywhere that homeownership opportunities are presented. Condominium ownership also resonates with the neoliberalization of urban space and urban life by contributing to the increased commodification of space, and by drawing city dwellers into the social, political, and economic structures of property ownership, which are assumed to produce a more conservative polity.

Housing, while always viewed as a commodity in the capitalist economy, is increasingly seen as a vehicle for capital accumulation under neoliberal economic regimes (Blomley, 2004). Condominiums are well-suited to exchange on the housing market because their relatively low purchase price and low-maintenance make them attractive as investments to sell or rent out. Jon Caulfield (2005) describes condominiums as a predominant feature of corporatized urban space, defined by geographer Edward Relph as “a potential commodity to be exploited, managed or manipulated in whatever ways will ensure ... profitability” (1987, p. 188). The massive numbers of condominium units opens a network for the increased (and more rapid) circulation of capital through the housing market, increasing the potential for capital accumulation both by large-scale global investors and individual homeowners.

In the urban context, condominium owners are assumed to have an economic interest in keeping property taxes and interest rates low, and little interest in maintaining rent control, affordable housing, housing quality, or housing assistance. Rather, condominium owners’ interests may lie in maintaining their property values by practicing urban NIMBY-ism, creating segregated and securitized spaces in the city’s core. Rowland Atkinson (2006) describes these practices as “padding the bunker,” and notes that private developers and urban planners respond to the needs and desires of the middle class by creating privatized, insulated spaces, ignoring the consequences of segregation and plunging into “a headlong drive to attract homeowners and their equation with economic growth” (2006, p. 824). The choices of homeowners—for security, for interconnected work, leisure, and dwelling spaces, and for spectacle and entertainment—are seen as private, legitimate decisions that are “intrinsically unproblematic” (Atkinson, 2006, p. 830). In the particular political-economic context of neoliberal urbanism, attracting homeowners with these desires articulates neatly with a broader urban agenda of growth, competition, militarization, and commodification. Thus condominium development brings homeowners into the core, and the desires of homeowners for security, both personal and financial, legitimize a neoliberal urban agenda.

However, it cannot be assumed that homeownership in general, and condominium ownership in particular, automatically produces a “neoliberal citizen” with revanchist ideals about city life. Indeed, the ways that different condominium dwellers engage with the city, or conceptualize their sense of belonging to the city, have not been explored substantively. Given the longstanding association between homeownership and good citizenship in property-owning democracies (Blomley, 2004; Harris, 2004; Atkinson and Blandy, 2007), it is important to question the ways in which the shifting tenure structure of the city may affect the nature of people’s attachments to, or engagements with, city life and local issues without assuming a straightforward, top-down influence by the broader neoliberal objectives shaping city-building, or that neoliberal imperatives are the only forces shaping citizenship in this context. Therefore, in the latter portion of this article, I will examine the dimension of condominium ownership from the vantage point of

everyday life, following Larner (2003), Peck (2004), and others who note the unevenness of neoliberalism “on the ground” (Leitner et al., 2007).

The Question of Sprawl? The Answer Is Private Redevelopment

The current (2007) provincial government in Ontario, under the leadership of Premier Dalton McGuinty, was elected in 2003 partly based on its promise to halt rapid development in ecologically sensitive areas north of Toronto such as the Oak Ridges Moraine. Despite its unsuccessful attempt to literally stop the bulldozers in mid-construction, the provincial government passed the Greenbelt Act in 2005 (Government of Ontario, 2005), legislation designed to limit exurban development and encourage intensification in the core areas of the cities of the GTA. The Places to Grow Act (Government of Ontario, 2005) was also passed in 2005, defining zones for urban growth and intensification, and limiting suburban sprawl. These policies provide a regional justification for the city’s reurbanization-focused Official Plan (City of Toronto, 2002), and serve as a legislative backbone for high-density development, which is often controversial in a region that has experienced most of its growth through suburbanization.

Whereas suburban development has not been halted in the GTA, rising land costs, combined with the availability of cheaper downtown housing in the form of condominiums, has slowed low-rise, single-family home construction, and reversed inner-city population decline (Bourne, 2000; Meligrana and Skaburskis, 2005). But the reliance on private-sector financing, building, and management of residential projects (almost all of which are in the form of condominiums) is representative of a major shift in housing strategy. The 2002 *Official Plan* is certainly not the first such document to value intensification and an increase in urban population. The 1994 plan, *The Liveable Metropolis*, and the 1983 plan, *The Official Plan for the Urban Structure* (Metropolitan Toronto Council, 1983, 1994), also sought population growth in the core of the metropolitan region. However, previous rounds of intensification involved strong public-sector participation. Throughout the 1980s, for example, the public-sector model of residential development sought to encourage a mix of classes and land uses in the core, and funded numerous mixed-use social housing projects (Wekerle, 1988, 1993, 2005). The federal and provincial governments, as well as the city’s housing department, supported non-profit housing projects initiated and controlled by groups with particular and pressing housing needs, including single parents, seniors, women of color, lesbians, and new immigrants. As neoliberal political regimes came to power in the mid-1990s, particularly the provincial regime of conservative Premier Mike Harris, funding for social housing was withdrawn, forcing the city to scale back its own role in social housing (City of Toronto, 2003).

Although these policies respond to growing public concern over the ecological consequences of sprawl, this issue has gained solid political traction by emphasizing the troubling economic factors, such as the high costs of land, gasoline, highway infrastructure, and expanding public transit beyond city limits. Susannah Bunce’s (2004) analysis of the language of “smart growth” and reintensification in Toronto’s *Official Plan* and other recent planning documents suggests, however, that “the environmental problems of regional sprawl serve as a public rationale for the primary municipal goal of increasing Toronto’s economic and land-use development through private-sector investment and the

attraction of skilled, professional labour to the city” (p. 180). Functionally, the Greenbelt legislation limits the potential for developers to buy exurban land cheaply by imposing restrictions that make this land supply scarce. The low-density zoning regulations in suburban areas also mean that developers will not maximize their profits through increased density in these areas. Coupled with a developer-friendly municipal planning approval and appeals board (the Ontario Municipal Board), the rezoning of industrial and commercial lands, and relaxed height and density restrictions, urban property development has become highly attractive.

This roll-out of environmental discourse and policy can be read as part of the neoliberalization of governance, wherein the state enacts various policy prescriptions designed to open up particular markets to increased penetration by capital. In this case, the state has not fully withdrawn from the control of land supply and development; indeed the state appears to be taking an active role in conserving and protecting vulnerable land, but has reorganized its interventions in ways that free up other spaces for massive redevelopment. The “greenwashing” of intensification means that critical questions about the process and outcomes of urban redevelopment are effectively evaded. Few are challenging the city’s reliance on the small group of powerful decision-makers who shape land-building markets (Fainstein, 2001; MacLaran, 2003) to spearhead the capitalist restructuring of the city, meaning that both the resulting forms of redevelopment and the process itself will likely reflect the interests and ideals of a particular set of stakeholders.

Leaving residential intensification to the private sector, and supporting large-scale private redevelopment projects, seemingly allows the city to decrease its role in providing public spaces and public services. The *Official Plan* notes that private developers are expected to include “community” services within their projects (City of Toronto, 2002, pp. 42–43). But the private nature of these facilities in condominium projects means they are not publicly accessible (Grant et al., 2004; Townshend, 2006). Condominiums typically include some combination of amenities, including private security, private fitness facilities, spaces for socializing, playgrounds, and private outdoor space. If the community needs of new urban residents are met through privatized development, the city has a decreased need to fund or expand the public realm or public services. Accordingly, private development is seen as an effective way of managing the costs associated with residential intensification. In actuality, however, there are many hidden costs associated with increasing densities, both in terms of hard and soft infrastructures, that must be absorbed by various levels of government, and of course taxpayers (Logan and Molotch, 1987; Nyden et al., 2006). Thus neoliberal economic ideals of privatization of public services are not likely to be effectively met through condominium development and increased density.

Intensify or Die: A Spatial and Social Fix for Deindustrialization

Intensification in the form of condominiums is also portrayed as a solution to many of the problems of deindustrialization (City of Toronto, 2002). It is meant to serve as both a spatial and a social fix. The deindustrialized city is positioned as nonvital and nonvibrant, and full of decaying, struggling spaces. Condominiums then serve as a means of urban revitalization, reusing old spaces as sites for capital investment and capital accumulation in the city, much as Neil Smith (1979) described in his early work on the rent gap.

Condominiums also draw the middle class to the central city, thus presenting a social fix for the deindustrialized city that has experienced most of its population loss through suburban sprawl.

Critical urban scholars argue that revitalization through the redevelopment of urban property represents a new and powerful wave of gentrification (Smith, 1996; Lees, 2000). This wave differs from traditional modes of gentrification, in that large-scale property redevelopment is led by capital, rather than individual homeowners, and is often facilitated by state interventions. Gentrification through redevelopment, Smith (2002) asserted, is a "global urban strategy" increasingly shaped by global capital. Smith (1996) has also argued that residential intensification is "the leading residential edge of a much larger endeavor: the class remake of the central urban landscape" (p. 39). Unlike previous rounds of gentrification under the rubric of revitalization, the state actively removes the legislative and zoning barriers that were set up to limit the redevelopment of vulnerable neighborhoods, or to protect public space (Hackworth and Smith, 2001). Revitalization through better design and new development functions is, in effect, to "revitalize" urban capital accumulation strategies by opening new sites for investment despite a relative scarcity of land. The beneficiaries of revitalization are landowners, financiers, developers, investors, and builders, and the middle class and elites to whom the redeveloped city caters (Lees, 2000; Smith, 2002).

These critics of contemporary redevelopment plans tie these tactics to revanchist urban agendas that operate through an abstract view of property, seeing it solely in terms of its exchange, rather than its use, value. Blomley (2004) notes that the rise of contemporary urban neoliberalism "has increasingly embraced the principle of highest and best use as a metric for urban land use and planning decisions, abandoning a logic of community and neighbourhood" (p. 84). He critiques the logic of the "highest and best use" of land, which under advanced liberalism, means private ownership, private development, and the potential for profit. Loretta Lees (2000) notes that discourses of urban renaissance and revitalization "promote gentrification as a blueprint for a civilized city" (p. 404), based on the assumption that middle-class interests constitute the "highest and best use" of urban space. Other authors have problematized the ways that urban design and revitalization discourse appears to take an interest in "public space," while actually facilitating the growth of privatized spaces that are defined by exclusive boundaries, or geared solely to consumption activities (Zukin, 1998; Soja, 2000; Graham and Marvin, 2001). This estheticization and commodification of urban space through condominium development may be an effective way to prime the postindustrial city for an influx of capital investment, thus neoliberalizing Toronto's urban fabric; however, the long-term consequences of industrial and commercial displacement and the stress on the city's infrastructure caused by a focus on a single type of land use have yet to be assessed (Weber, 2002; Curran, 2004; Curran and Hanson, 2005).

Residential intensification is meant to create the kinds of neighborhoods, social infrastructure, and lifestyle spaces that are believed to appeal to the new middle class: the professional, cultural, and knowledge workers who will fuel Toronto's postindustrial economy. In one sense, intensification is an attempt to capitalize on the demographic effects of urban restructuring, which has produced an increasingly polarized labor force based on both low-wage, deskilled, service-sector labor, and highly professionalized labor in the advanced tertiary and quaternary sectors (Ley, 1996; Bourne and Rose,

2001). While the deskilled labor force and new immigrants are increasingly settling in peripheral areas (Siemiatycki and Isin, 1997), the new urban middle class formed by these changes (Ley, 1996) has stimulated demand for new housing and services in the city. Demands include inner-city housing options such as condominiums, as well as consumer services, leisure activities, and recreational spaces. These demands are fulfilled through redevelopment agendas.

The social aspects of intensification have not received a great deal of public attention, although a recent article in the *Toronto Star* (Cotronco, 2006) drew attention to both the social challenges of intensified living and the ways that condominium communities form and interact. Residents were attempting to translate the common ownership structure into a common social structure by setting up activities and events within their condominium community. However, the impacts of this privatized form of community in terms of the effects on broader engagements with the city requires further investigation. The common ownership structure and monthly fees mean that residents have a vested interest in their own amenities, and fewer requirements for open and accessible public space, public recreation, or entertainment, or public provision of family programs (Fincher, 2004). The question remains, does intensification facilitate the formation of healthy urban communities, or are these communities so narrow and exclusive that the scale of "local" citizenship practices is reduced from the city or neighborhood to the individual, private condominium building?

This discussion has illustrated some of the many ways that condominiums have come to be positioned as a natural solution to a variety of urban problems. Peck (2001, p. 448) conceptualizes the ability of the neoliberal state to naturalize its strategies as "a form of high politics represented as non-political." That is, neoliberal solutions are represented as imperatives of intercity global competition, rather than as politically constructed situations in which the state exercises choice. The effect of this is a rather large silence around how condominium development, and the experience of condominium living, might be reshaping the social, economic, and political landscapes of the city. Larner (2003) suggests that neoliberalism is comprised of sets of co-evolving discourses and practices that intersect to produce particular, contextual, on-the-ground effects. Although it is not the aim of this study to assess the macro-level political and economic consequences of condominium development, I have thus far noted that as a form of privatization and commodification, condominiums may not prove effective at stimulating growth, competition, or prosperity at the municipal level as the economic costs of pursuing a major round of residential intensification are not fully known or acknowledged. In the following section, I offer an exploration of some of the social consequences of condominium development in order to understand particular aspects of the "on-the-ground" effects of neoliberalization from the vantage point of everyday life.

RESHAPING PUBLIC AND PRIVATE LIFE: MEANINGS AND PRACTICES OF URBAN LIVING FOR WOMEN CONDOMINIUM OWNERS

In 2002, a *Toronto Star* real estate reporter described a revelatory moment among condominium developers and industry analysts:

As industry insiders sat around marvelling at the seemingly limitless appetite for downtown condominiums in the last few years, it gradually dawned on them that the single woman, as purchaser, was a force to be reckoned with. Buried in the sales data they found evidence of a significant sociological shift. (Cordileone, 2002)

While this anecdote evokes an amusing image of smug condominium developers “marveling” at their record profits, only to be struck by the deep insight that they may in fact be heralding the dawn of a new age of women’s emancipation, the reporter is not completely misguided in attributing the discovery of this “significant sociological shift” to the condominium industry. This shift has not been noted and discussed by urban scholars, despite the questions it raises about the social impacts of gentrification, property redevelopment, and urban revitalization as well as concerns about women’s relationships to the contemporary postindustrial city.

Across Canada, the 2001 census data showed that female one-person households comprised the largest group of condominium owners, with 10.7% of these households owning a condominium, almost double the condominium ownership rate for Canadian households in general (5.8%; Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation, 2001). In Toronto, single women are estimated to make up approximately 40% of new and resale condominium purchasers in the city (Cordileone, 2002). Women’s important role in the urban condominium market is also illustrated by the way condominiums are advertised. In conducting a visual analysis of twelve typical editions of the weekly advertising magazine *Condo Guide* from 2006, I observed that women were included in approximately 87% of all the ads that featured people, and approximately 47% of those ads featured only women.

Feminist and critical urban scholars have (to a somewhat limited extent) addressed gender in the context of entrepreneurial urban restructuring across several relevant themes, including the reshaping of urban governance and urban citizenship, gentrification, sexuality and urban space, and property development. Popular sources such as the news media have also identified gender as a salient dimension of recent urban trends. Liz Bondi and Damaris Rose (2003) have commented on the need to apply theories about the constitution of gendered identities to research on large-scale redevelopment and new residential communities. However, there are still few projects addressing the construction of gender (in relation to other socially produced differences) through contemporary neoliberal urbanism or the ways in which neoliberal urbanism is itself shaped by gender.

Kern and Wekerle (2008) analyze the “gendered politics of city-building” in Toronto by looking at how a narrow group of stakeholders shapes urban policy in ways that exclude all groups whose interests are believed to contradict or lie outside of the regime of competitiveness. Others (e.g., Chouinard, 1996; Tickell and Peck, 1996; Abrar, Lovenduski, and Margetts, 1998; Brownhill, 2000) have examined the “regendering” of local governance as decision-making power is increasingly transferred from the local state to various other decision-making structures and agents. Sylvia Bashevkin’s recent study (2006) contrasting local state restructuring and its gendered consequences in Toronto and London attempted to place changes in policy and planning within the context of neoliberal ideologies. Her work shows that the specific, contextual manifestations of neoliberalization can lead to very different gendered outcomes, for example, the total dismissal of gender issues from city planning in Toronto. Susan Fainstein (2001) has

pointed out that the privatization of urban space through massive redevelopment projects effectively reinforces the power and vision of the White men who control such projects, resulting in a city that symbolizes masculine power.

Interestingly, gendered narratives are increasingly used to “sell” revitalization as good social policy. Toronto’s *Official Plan*, while declining to specifically mention women at all, suggests that reurbanization will help to create a more accessible and equitable environment for the city’s diverse population. More explicitly, the news media have picked up on several themes, particularly with respect to condominium development, that seem to support the notion that intensification and a return to the city are important sources of emancipation for women (Southworth, 1999; Delap, 2006). These sources have co-opted a watered-down feminist version of the notion that city life can be beneficial for women. In early feminist research on women and cities, Gerda Wekerle (1984) and others (e.g., Rose, 1984) argued that “women’s place is in the city” based on the service needs of mothers, particularly low-income single mothers who would have greater access to publicly funded infrastructures such as transit, affordable housing, and childcare. Elizabeth Wilson (1991) noted that urban environments permit a degree of autonomy, anonymity, and freedom from traditional gender roles that was unlikely to be found in suburbs or small towns. These themes have been recirculated in contemporary popular discourse around women and city life; however, they are emptied of any redistributive or equity concerns in favor of an individualized, consumption-oriented vision of “freedom” and gender equality.

The high level of female participation in the condominium market suggests that it is timely to consider how condominiums reshape women’s relationship to the city. As privatized housing that is focused on fulfilling user needs in individualized, commodified ways, condominium living may be deeply de-politicizing. If, as feminist urban theory suggests, “any settlement is an inscription in space of the social relations in the society that built it” (Darke, 1996, p. 88), how do condominiums express new ideals of urban citizenship within a neoliberal political-economic context?

Methodology

This study is based on in-depth interviews conducted from 2005–2006 with 21 women condominium owners, recruited through a snowballing process that began with acquaintances and contacts in the real estate industry. The interviews explored the meanings of condominium ownership and city living, and the transcripts were analyzed through both a set of predetermined codes as well as codes that emerged from the narratives themselves. The participants ranged in age from 21 to 46, and they were from a variety of ethnic and religious backgrounds. All had at least some post-secondary education. Two participants were full-time graduate students, and the remainder were employed full-time, either as professionals in their chosen fields or as clerical and administrative workers. The majority (17) lived alone; 2 were married, 2 had roommates, and only 1 had a child. Nineteen were first-time homeowners and 2 had previously owned another condominium. Overall, this group represents the young or single working female condominium owner, the “typical” condominium consumer according to the news media and condominium industry. Whereas the sample size is not sufficiently large to generate broad conclusions, the lack of similar research means that this study will suggest critical avenues for further large-scale

investigations. It is also important to note that in interviewing women who had specifically chosen to become condominium owners, I have collected narratives that are more likely to support the ideals of condominium living and to justify the choices of these condominium buyers than if I had also interviewed women who had made other housing choices. However, this choice reflects an interest in disrupting the seamless narrative of condominium living as empowerment by examining some of the everyday meanings and experiences of the women who reside in condominiums. So while focusing on one (relatively privileged) group of women in the city has narrowed the range of potential responses to condominium development, it is also necessary empirically to gather and analyze the stories of such women in order to counter the sound-bite characterizations of condominium living as emancipatory. Nonetheless, I acknowledge that the story told here is necessarily partial and contingent on the methodological choices made.

An initial reading of the interview data suggests that condominium living seems to offer and perhaps enhance many of the same gendered advantages of city life that have been described by feminist geographers, including proximity to work and leisure, transit options, diversity, anonymity, safety, and a sense of freedom in public space (Wekerle, 1984; Wilson, 1991; Kern, 2005). Most women also attached a great deal of significance to becoming a homeowner, which resonates with two decades of quantitative and qualitative research into women's struggles to overcome entrenched, systemic disadvantage in the Canadian housing market (McClain and Doyle, 1983; Klodawsky and Mackenzie, 1987; Novac, 1990, 1995, 1996), and with the difficulties and constrained choices faced by people wishing to break into an inflated urban housing market. These factors led women to articulate a sense of independence and freedom arising from their decisions. Condominiums indeed provide access to very important social and economic factors that contribute to a high quality of life for women who still face a gendered income gap. Without dismissing these benefits, however, I wish to tease out the tensions and contradictions that arise as shifting notions of public and private shape women condominium owners' engagements with city life.

Tenure: Women and Homeownership in the City

Condominiums provide a way for women to access the social and economic advantages of homeownership that single women in particular have often been excluded from (Novac, 1995). In this study, women expressed a clear preference for owning that was framed primarily in economic terms, as a form of financial freedom and autonomy.

I'm not really planning to make a lot of money, but I feel like I can't really lose. I mean with rent, I was getting—there was no chance of anything. Rent was a black hole, I threw my money away, I burnt my money. With my condo, depending on how long I stay, and looking at the location where I am, it's never going to go down. (Colleen, age 28)⁴

⁴All participants have been assigned pseudonyms.

I don't think I'd ever go back to renting. It just feels so much better to invest in something that you're going to get your money out of later, and then some, and that you just have a lot more freedom with, that you can do a lot more to and a lot more with than you would bother investing in somewhere that you were renting. So, yeah, I'd say it's really important. I think, too, at my stage of life, or however you put it, I think it's kind of ridiculous to be renting, so it means a lot. (Caitlin, age 30)

It's very freeing to go from renting to owning. (Amanda, age 29)

As Robyn Dowling (1998) found in a study of homeowners in British Columbia, women often conceptualize the value of their homes in financial and not just social terms, despite gendered stereotypes that would seem to suggest women are more concerned with the home as the center of family life. In my study, it seems that these narratives are shaped by, or reflect, the dominant culture of property that values and rewards homeownership as a wise financial decision, and as an important step toward economic security or independence. Viewed through a feminist lens that questions the ways in which women's "freedom" is constructed, the positive valuation of homeownership as independence, autonomy, and freedom suggests that women's independence is being recast as a function of their control over the private sphere of the home, at least financially. Read against a shift toward neoliberal forms of urban governance, this suggests that the neoliberal emphasis on the value of private property ownership is translated into women's everyday lives through condominium ownership. Given the longstanding association of homeowners with responsible, stable citizenship (Harris, 2004)—and conversely, renters with irresponsibility and transience (Slater, 2004) condominium ownership appears to function as a way of drawing young, middle-class women into the social, economic, political, and moral structure of private property ownership (Blomley, 2004), and thereby into a particular model of citizenship based on an economic form of engagement with the city. The ways that homeownership works to tie women to the public sphere through their emancipation in the private sphere illustrates the complex intertwining of "public" and "private" that occurs as more and more women access the world of homeownership through condominiums. Nonetheless, some of the women interviewed expressed concern over the difficulties of paying a mortgage, especially as single women:

I didn't want to kind of live outside my budget, and live outside my means, and live for my mortgage. I didn't want to do that, because, you know, you have friends who buy beautiful condos, live by themselves, and they eat cereal. (Jillian, age 30)

The notion of freedom expressed in these narratives seems to reflect a commodified, consumer-based model of freedom. From a feminist perspective, it is necessary to note the tensions between the possibility that homeownership at an early age, particularly within a culture that rewards homeownership and effectively punishes alternative tenures, may release women from one dimension of patriarchal control. However, patriarchy does not operate solely at the scale of the household or the family; it also permeates broader economic and political structures. Moreover, as Jillian suggests, becoming beholden to a mortgage is not necessarily freeing. Thus we cannot conclude here that homeownership is necessarily a form of gendered emancipation. At the same time, I would not dismiss the

potential value of homeownership for those women who are able to attain it in terms of its specific financial benefits.

Security: Control and Enclosure

The importance of control over the private sphere of the home is also evident in narratives about safety and security. The security features of condominium buildings, such as 24-hour concierge service, key card entry, and even hand-print door locks, are touted as key reasons why women choose this form of urban dwelling (Fincher, 2004). Indeed, most of the participants in this study considered security to be an important factor in their choice of condominium.

As a single woman living on her own, I think the security is a big issue. Especially living in downtown Toronto, you always hear stories of crazy things that happen, so that is definitely a big thing. (Rachel, age 22)

The concierge is actually a really big thing. I don't think I'd feel as comfortable living right in downtown Toronto. I mean I love the location but there's just a fair number of homeless people and not that far away there's drug dealers and prostitutes and stuff like that. You know I feel completely comfortable in this building. I've never felt uncomfortable here once. And I think the concierge, knowing that they're there, that's part of that. The pass-codes, things like that, there's card entry. And video cameras, like surveillance cameras in the underground parking garage. So all that stuff contributes to making it feel comfortable living here. (Sandra, age 28)

These comments illustrate that personal safety is still an important issue for women living in the central city, one that they are willing to take individual responsibility for by paying (through their monthly condominium fees) for security personnel and technology.

The emphasis on security in the private space of the home is quite interesting, given that women are deeply socialized to feel fear in the public spaces of the city (Valentine, 1989; Pain, 1997). In part this shift has occurred because many condominium developments are located in areas of the city with few established residential communities, and are thus isolated from the sense of safety that comes from busy streets and a plethora of neighbors (Kern, 2005). However, this does not fully explain why the discourse around gender and urban safety now emphasizes the need for women to secure their safety within their homes, rather than on the streets. This shift, to focusing on safety in private space, may instead be a result of the shift toward an ethic of individual responsibility and the commodification of social objectives. It may also reflect a desire for a sense of enclosure and privacy, rather than public freedom. As Mike Davis (1991) suggests,

"Security" becomes a positional good defined by income access to private "protective services" and membership in some hardened residential enclave or restricted suburb.... "[S]ecurity" has less to do with personal safety than with the degree of personal insulation, in residential, work, consumption and travel environments, from "unsavory" groups and individuals, even crowds in general. (Davis, 1991, p. 224)

Thus the emphasis on private security provided by condominium developments is premised on the notion that women's safety is a personal lifestyle choice, rather than a political issue that must be pursued collectively. Problematically, safety, if it is seen as a private choice exercised in private space, becomes a function of privilege (Day, 1999; Kern, 2005), rather than a good available to all women. In Toronto, safety has long been a primary motivation for women's urban activism (Whitzman, 1992, 2002; Andrew, 1995; MacGregor, 1995). In an urban environment increasingly filled with private, gated spaces, where safety is seen as a commodity that can be chosen and purchased, there is little political motivation to pursue collective action to ensure that all citizens, in both private and public spaces, have access to security. As Bashevkin (2006) notes, women's actions concerning safety have become increasingly marginal in Toronto since the restructuring of urban government and a renewed interest in urban revitalization strategies.

Women's gendered vulnerabilities (Fincher, 2004) are also used to legitimate the wider "militarization of space" (Davis, 1991) that occurs when private developments police their surroundings and set up exclusionary boundaries. The women in this study seemed acutely aware that their condominium developments were part of a broader gentrification process that was transforming downtown neighborhoods into safer consumption-oriented or tourist sites:

When I first moved in people would come out at three o'clock in the morning, drunk, and start fights, and I actually saw this one guy getting his head kicked in.... I guess the fact that they're building a condo across the street is actually a deterrent to that. (Sandra, age 28)

What I don't like is the immediate vicinity. Because it's a big tourist trap. And also some of the businesses that have started to come into the area, the area has started to get more developed, with more condos. And also the area has started to get all these tourist-type shops. (Ava, age 32)

The condo in the Distillery, while it was a really hot neighborhood at the time, by the time I sold it, it was like, you know big hype around it. When I first moved in there, even the pizza guys wouldn't come to my place ... They were worried that I would have somebody there to mug them. ... It was like completely deserted. But after five years, it doubled in price. (Naomi, age 29)

I think if anything, not that it's necessarily a good thing, but I think that the gentrification of the downtown area is gonna keep going, until the downtown is going to become almost as much of a safe little neighborhood as some of the older richer neighborhoods are. (Lynn, age 28)

Condominiums are reshaping the urban landscape in ways that prime the city for an influx of young professionals, tourists, and businesses. As Atkinson (2006) noted, "policies directed at the central city as an entertainment and lifestyle choice for the creative class ... seem largely detached from others tackling peripheral poverty, relative hopelessness, crime and disorder" (p. 821). Indeed, safety concerns may be deliberately evaded by policymakers seeking to attract homeowners, and young women homeowners in particular.

For example, Alec Brownlow (2006) has explored how police statistics on sexual violence in Philadelphia were deceptively labeled to avoid portraying the city as dangerous for young, middle class, White women. These strategies—privatizing safety, producing militarized urban spaces, and making safety issues invisible—are both decreasing the perceived need for collective action on safety and decreasing the amount of public space available for the all-important meeting of strangers (Young, 1990) or eyes on the street (Jacobs, 1961).

Despite their appreciation for the various security measures offered by the condominium, all of the women interviewed here expressed comfort with the urban environment and a general sense of safety, belonging, and confidence that cannot be attributed to private security features. The willingness of some women to move to less-established neighborhoods or poorer areas of the city can be read as resistance to the broad socialization of women into fear of urban space (Pain, 1991; Koskela, 1997). For the women condominium owners interviewed here, safety was one dimension of the choice to buy a condominium, and in the context of a city that has allowed women's safety to drop off the public agenda, it seems to be a legitimate concern. However, the ways in which safety is understood and accessed, suggest that our notions of the public and private dimensions of safety are shifting in ways that emphasize the increasingly private nature of city life within enclosed condominium communities.

Constructing Community

If security and a sense of enclosure are indeed a feature of condominium living for women owners, how do women engage with, or create, communities within condominium developments? How do women engage with the neighborhoods in which their condominiums are located? In this study, several women articulated a sense of community within their buildings, but this did not seem to translate into attachment to the neighborhood as a whole. Indeed, the condominium lifestyle may make neighborhood connections redundant for many.

They [developers] also wanted to have an area where people could get together, and kind of entertain, and meet other people and socialize. So those were the big things for the facility, the rooftop garden, the barbeque area, and I think the way that they created it was very much like a common area, so you feel like you're at home and you get to meet new people. (Jillian, age 30)

It hasn't got a whole bunch of shops along there, so it doesn't get a lot of foot traffic. It feels like your space when you get home, you're not sort of sharing it with everybody. (Jennifer, age 29)

So without wanting all the responsibilities of a house, I still wanted it to feel a little bit like a community.... We actually had a barbeque where it was like all the owners, kind of a seasonal barbeque kind of thing where everybody could get together and meet each other, which is I guess something that tends to happen at street parties. So I think it's kind of nice to have that sort of feel in a building.... But at the same time I kind of like the fact that it's not like everybody on your street knows

exactly what you're doing, all the time.... For me it's a lot about independence. (Sandra, age 28)

Actually [another condo resident] and I work together, we didn't before, we met in this building, and there was another girl who lived in the building who also had her own business, and the three of us, over the past year or so have gotten so much business out of each other, and have started this little like network, business network, between the three of us, and it's just been crazy how much business we've got through each other. (Naomi, age 29)

These participants articulate the ways in which the quasi-public shared spaces of the condominium can facilitate the development of social and economic networks among residents, and among female residents in particular. By creating new kinds of spaces that are neither fully private nor fully public, condominium developments produce opportunities for residents to engage with one another as individuals, and as a community. As feminist housing scholars such as Dolores Hayden (2002) have often argued, communal living arrangements can be highly beneficial to women, especially when contrasted to the isolating features of single-family, low-density housing. However, this type of community formation can be problematically insular, as residents are in effect preselecting their community to congregate with individuals of similar social and economic status. The formation of communities of difference (Young, 1990) is unlikely to be achieved if "community" is experienced behind the gates of a condominium rather than in the neighborhood at large. At the same time, some of the women in this study resisted engaging with their condominium communities, expressing a desire for more privacy and anonymity:

Toronto's supposed to be this aloof city where nobody talks to each other, and I just moved into Sesame Street. I'm not kidding. It's shocking. And almost to the point where it's annoying.... I like being anonymous. I really, really do. Especially being a single woman, I don't like people knowing my business because you know, you don't know what creep lives next door. (April, age 37)

I like to have my own space. I don't want to be bothered by people that much. It works out. It's pretty much all professionals. There's not that many kids, and I personally don't really like to see kids running around all the time, so it works well for me.... I take the stairs to avoid small talk. (Chloe, age 23)

In resisting the forced social network of the condominium and seeking out increased privacy, these women challenge some of the gendered stereotypes that are used to position condominium living as empowering for women, in that they refuse to engage in collective activities and social bonding and prefer to maintain their independence. But for both women who enjoy and seek out a community, and those who actively avoid such groupings, it seems that as condominiums redefine the boundaries between public and private space, women's spaces of engagement and attachment are also redefined. Although it is important to acknowledge the support functions of the communities that may develop within condominiums, it is also necessary to be wary of the phenomenon of "padding the bunker" (Atkinson, 2006), or the "social tectonics" described by Butler and Robson (2003), whereby the residents of gentrified communities detach themselves from

the surrounding neighborhood and city as a whole, merely passing by people of differing socioeconomic status without meaningful interactions. These new urban residents, who can (and are expected to) purchase market services, may have a limited stake in maintaining quality public education, community centers, and/or services for new immigrants and lower-income households. Davidson and Lees (2005) suggest that these gentrifiers engage in a private lifestyle with little connection to, or investment in, the local neighborhood.

Proximity: "Taking Advantage" of the City

Beyond the gates of the condominium, leisure pursuits and consumption activities are an important part of daily life in the postindustrial city. For the women in this study, downtown condominiums were viewed as living spaces that facilitated their ability to "take advantage" of these aspects of city living.

I think for me it would just be the fascination of, you know, I have the whole city to myself. Whatever I choose to do I can go and do it. That sort of thing. Kind of like going on a date with a big city. You can go anywhere, just have like a really fabulous time. (Jillian, age 30)

I like the noise. I like the amount of people, most of the time. And just the fact that I can pretty much do what I want, when I want. Everything's available to me. I think that's what I like. (Hope, age 29)

I want to experience all the city has to offer. A lot of events that go on, I try to attend those. Whatever there is to do, I want to do it. (Colleen, age 28)

Work brings me into the city, and while I'm here, I've learned to love it and I might as well take advantage of it.... For me the reason for living downtown is because you're so close to everything. (Amanda, age 29)

This resonates with Smith's (1996) concept of the urban pioneer, reclaiming the city for the middle classes and remaking it as a site of spectacle and elite leisure activities. In applying a gendered lens to this concept, it is important to acknowledge that for women the ability to participate in city life is potentially liberating (Wilson, 1991). However, this model of "liberation" is focused on leisure, entertainment, and consumption:

My number one pastime is shopping, and number two would be movies, and they're both available. (Jaime, age 33)

I made the decision last summer to try to look at Toronto as a tourist would, and check things out. So last summer I started going to like the Bata Shoe Museum, I've been to the ROM [Royal Ontario Museum], I've been to the AGO [Art Gallery of Ontario], went over to the Islands.... I started to make a concerted effort to actually see things in the city, and indulge in this stuff. (Stephanie, age 35)

Oh I love the festivals. I would go to like every festival.... I take a lot of advantage of living in the city. (Rose, age 22)

“Taking advantage” of urban amenities is a way of relating to the city that is not a straightforward form of gendered emancipation; rather, this process interlocks with class privilege to promote a mode of urban living where consumption is the new citizenship. Condominium dwellers are courted by the city because of their potential to bring economic benefits to the downtown core. These benefits of downtown living are premised on a definition of quality of life that focuses on spectacle and consumption, rather than on improving equitable access to the public realm (Kipfer and Keil, 2002). This is largely congruent with a neoliberal philosophy that encourages increased privatization of public spaces and public events in order to promote the competitive city. As condominiums draw more people into the core that desire, and can pay for, the Disneyfication of urban space (Zukin, 1998), the benefits of proximity will be redefined as the ability of the middle class to access and remake urban space in its own image.

For middle-class women, this model of engagement with the city harkens back to 19th-century ideologies about the place and role of women in the urban landscape (Domosh, 1996), when it was as consumers that women could legitimately experience the public spaces and public freedoms of the city. In contemporary Western cities, women are again expected to find freedom and fulfillment through their leisure and consumption activities, which are facilitated by the proximity provided through condominium living. This seems to represent a symbolic shrinking of the public sphere for women, wherein public space is not the space of work or politics but the space of shopping, dining, and entertainment. However, many of the women in this study also expressed a sense that they could not (due to lack of time or financial constraints), or would not (due to general indifference), visit the city’s attractions or cultural venues, suggesting that it may be premature for the city to assume that the new residents will justify the massive expense of other forms of urban revitalization.

CONCLUSIONS

In grappling with questions of how a particular form of new-build gentrification is both legitimated in public discourse, and experienced by a particular group of city dwellers, I have suggested that the “emancipation” of women through condominium ownership must be read against an increasing neoliberalization of urban life where values of privacy, autonomy, and consumption are forming the basis for a new model of urban citizenship. The empirical study reported here points to several ways that condominium ownership and condominium living might shift perceptions of public and private life in ways that impact on women’s sense of engagement with, and attachment to, their homes, neighborhoods, and city. The interpretations that I offered here suggest that the roll-out of homeownership opportunities through private condominium development may work to shape the kinds of “freedoms” experienced by women condominium owners. However, the outcomes are not straightforward: condominium ownership does offer women (who have the economic means) the opportunity to experience many of the benefits of homeownership and city living; at the same time, the ways these benefits are experienced suggest that the privatization of city life is continuing apace.

As dominant discourses and strategies position homeownership, intensification, and private redevelopment as natural, inevitable, necessary, and good, the needs and desires of gentrifiers are legitimated and prioritized. When the needs of city dwellers are assumed

to be centered on security, privacy, leisure, consumption, and profit, the relationship between people and place is manipulated in ways that are congruent with the neoliberal philosophy of market-run, privatized space and services. If a person's relationship to the city is redefined as one of consumer, spectator, and client, the city is no longer obligated to be a provider of social services, a promoter of difference, or an engineer of social justice. The reshaping of urban space through residential intensification alters the ways that rights claims are constituted and legitimated. The process of urban citizenship, of staking a claim to the city and asserting a sense of belonging in the city, may increasingly rest in the hands of those who can assert that claim privately through the market. In her 1998 article, Bondi questioned whether the changes in gendered notions of public and private space could indeed be considered emancipatory, because they were specifically connected to class privilege and limited in scope. I conclude this article with a similar sense that the freedoms experienced by women condominium owners do not represent a widespread change in the gendering of the social, economic, and political landscapes of the city, and that, indeed, the processes that direct such freedoms toward a socioeconomically privileged few are likely to have highly detrimental effects on the abilities of marginalized groups to claim space and rights in the competitive, postindustrial city.

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